01 / DEFINE

A brief people can use.

Start with the person and the decision. Choose the format after you can explain the problem.

01 The person

Who needs this? Describe what they are trying to do and the situation they are in.

02 The problem

What is stopping them? Write what you have observed. Keep the proposed solution separate.

03 The decision

What will this work help you decide? Name the decision and who needs to make it.

Try this sentence: We are working on [problem] for [person] so we can decide [decision].

02 / CHECK

Keep the evidence attached.

A brief should show what you know, what you are assuming, and what you still need to ask.

01 What do we know?

List observations you can support. Add the source, date and what the source cannot tell you.

02 What are we assuming?

Write the claims the plan relies on but that you have not checked. Keep them labelled as assumptions.

03 What needs a check?

Choose the unanswered question most likely to change the decision. Name how you will check it.

Example only: "Someone asked for a dashboard" is a request. It does not yet explain the task they need to complete.

03 / CHOOSE

Make the first version testable.

Agree on the boundaries before making. A small version should still help answer the question.

01 The first version

What will you make? Name the task it supports and what you will deliberately leave out.

02 The constraints

Record the time, budget, access and dependencies. Name decisions that still need an answer.

03 The first test

What will someone try? What will you observe? What response will make you continue, change or stop?

Keep a review date. A test can change the brief; record the new evidence and the reason for the change.

04 / WRITE

Your one-page brief.

Print this page or write on it with a PDF annotation tool. Keep answers short and sources close.

Person & task

Who needs it, and what are they trying to do?

Problem & decision

What prevents the task? What do we need to decide?

Evidence

What supports the brief? Add source IDs, links or dates.

Assumptions

What does the plan rely on that we have not checked?

First version

What will we make, and what will we leave out?

Constraints

What time, budget, access or dependencies limit the work?

First test

What will someone try? What response will change the plan?

Owner & review date

Who decides what to do next, and when?